

The Consequences of Excessive Digital Engagement on Children and Youth



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Q CONSEQUENCES

1. COMMON PHYSICAL IMPACTS

OBESITY AND RELATED HEALTH PROBLEMS:

Excessive digital use often leads to a sedentary lifestyle, reducing physical activity levels and contributing to obesity. Obesity, in turn, increases the risk of various health problems such as diabetes, cardiovascular diseases, and musculoskeletal disorders. (Andreassen et al, 2016)

POOR SLEEP QUALITY AFFECTING ACADEMIC PERFORMANCE, BEHAVIOR, AND MOOD: Children and youth who spend excessive time using digital devices often experience disrupted sleep patterns. The exposure to blue light emitted by screens and the engaging nature of digital content can interfere with the quality and duration of sleep, resulting in fatigue, difficulty concentrating, irritability, and diminished academic performance. (Choi et al, 2009)

BEHAVIORAL PROBLEMS SUCH AS ATTENTION ISSUES AND HYPERACTIVITY:

Extensive digital use has been associated with attention-deficit/hyperactivity disorder (ADHD)-like symptoms, including difficulties in sustaining attention, increased impulsivity, and hyperactivity. The constant multitasking and rapid shifts of attention required by digital activities may contribute to these behavioral issues.

VISUAL DISORDERS: Research often highlights a range of visual disorders linked to excessive screen time. These disorders can include digital eye strain, characterized by symptoms like dry eyes, eye fatigue, and headaches. Prolonged exposure to screens emitting blue light may also disrupt sleep patterns, potentially leading to sleep deprivation, which can further exacerbate visual discomfort and affect overall eye health. (Tychsen, L., & Foeller, P, 2020) and Ricci, 2021)

LOWER ACADEMIC ACHIEVEMENT DUE TO REDUCED ENGAGEMENT IN OTHER ACTIVITIES: When children and youth spend excessive time engaged in digital activities, they may neglect other important activities that contribute to their overall development, such as studying, reading, physical exercise, and social interactions. This can lead to lower academic achievement and a lack of well-rounded skills.

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2. PSYCHOLOGICAL EFFECTS ON CHILDREN

DECREASED SOCIAL SKILLS: Excessive digital use can hinder the development of vital social skills, such as effective communication, empathy, and conflict resolution. Children and youth may become more isolated and reliant on digital interactions, limiting their ability to establish and maintain meaningful relationships offline.

DECREASED ATTENTION SPAN AND ABILITY TO FOCUS: The constant exposure to digital stimuli, characterized by frequent interruptions, fast-paced content, and instant gratification, can contribute to shorter attention spans and reduced ability to concentrate on tasks that require sustained mental effort.

- Reduced attention span, Sleep disturbances, hyperactivity, and aggression (Clark et al, 2020)

SLEEP PROBLEMS: Similar to the impact on physical health, excessive digital use can disrupt sleep patterns, leading to difficulties falling asleep, staying asleep, or achieving restful sleep. This can result in daytime drowsiness, decreased cognitive functioning, and emotional disturbances.

INCREASED ANXIETY AND DEPRESSION: Research suggests a link between excessive digital use and higher rates of anxiety and depression among children and youth. The comparison of idealized online personas, cyberbullying, and the constant pressure to maintain online presence can contribute to increased stress levels and negative emotional well-being. (Xue et al, 2023)





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NEGATIVE BODY IMAGE: The exposure to unrealistic beauty standards and idealized body images on digital platforms can contribute to negative body image perceptions among children and youth. This may lead to body dissatisfaction, disordered eating patterns, and an increased risk of developing eating disorders.(Seabra et al., 2017)

NEGATIVE EFFECTS ON THE BRAIN: Excessive or inappropriate use of digital technology can lead to negative effects on the brain, such as:

- Activation of the brain's reward center and release of excess dopamine, leading to addiction
- Changes in the brain resulting from excessive technology use (Choi, J., 2019).

FEELINGS OF ISOLATION AND LONELINESS: Paradoxically, excessive digital use can lead to feelings of isolation and loneliness, despite the seemingly constant connection to others through online platforms. The lack of genuine human connection and the superficial nature of many online interactions can contribute to a sense of social disconnection and emotional distress. (Andreasen et al, 2016)

SUICIDAL IDEATION :

Highest levels of depression and suicidal ideation (Kim et al, 2006)

VULNERABILITY : Children are particularly vulnerable to persuasive tactics used in games (Van Rooij et al., 2021)

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3. SOCIAL EFFECT

INVOLVEMENT IN UNSAFE AND ILLEGAL ACTIVITIES: Excessive digital use can expose youth to various risks and potentially harmful situations, including engagement in unsafe and illegal activities facilitated by the online environment.

HARASSMENT: Online platforms can provide a breeding ground for harassment and cyberbullying, where youth may be subjected to verbal abuse, threats, and targeted attacks. This can have severe emotional and psychological consequences, leading to diminished self-esteem and increased anxiety.

PRIVACY VIOLATION: Excessive digital use may compromise the privacy of youth, as personal information and activities can be easily accessed and exploited by malicious individuals. The lack of understanding regarding privacy settings and safe online practices can further exacerbate this risk.

DEFAMATION OF CHARACTER: Digital platforms enable the rapid dissemination of information, making it easier for false or damaging information about youth to spread quickly. This can harm their reputation, cause emotional distress, and even lead to long-lasting consequences in their personal and professional lives.



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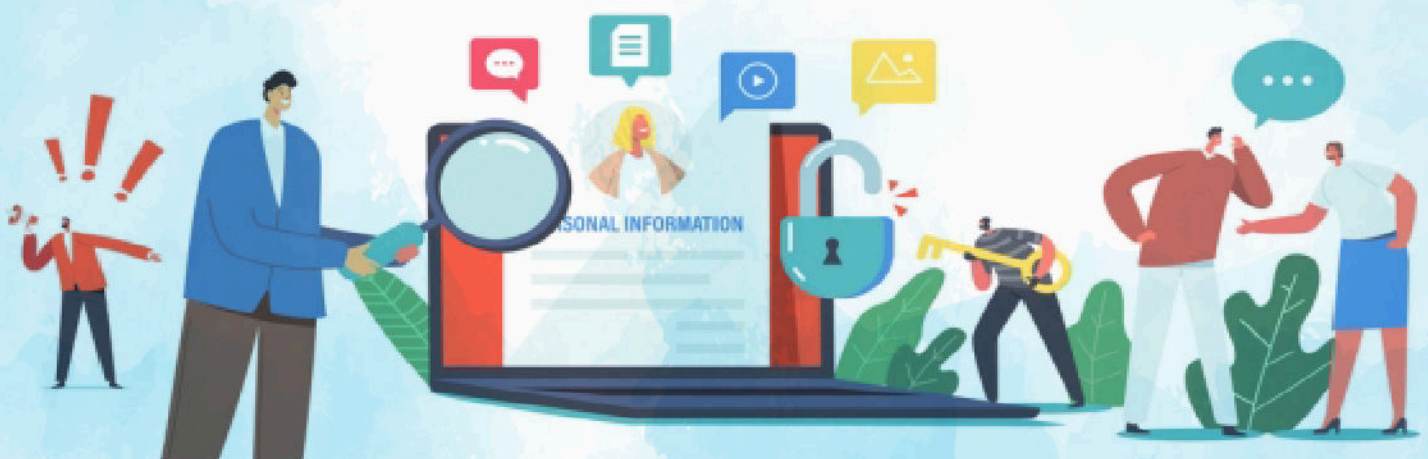
INTENTIONAL INFLICTION OF EMOTIONAL DISTRESS: Online interactions can sometimes involve intentional efforts to harm or distress others. Youth may be targeted with hurtful comments, threats, or offensive content, leading to significant emotional distress and potential psychological trauma.

BULLYING: Cyberbullying, a form of bullying that takes place online, can have severe consequences for youth. It involves repeated acts of aggression, harassment, or intimidation through digital channels, and can result in emotional distress, social isolation, and even self-harm or suicidal ideation.

EXPOSURE TO INAPPROPRIATE INFORMATION: Excessive digital use exposes youth to a wide range of content, some of which may be inappropriate or harmful. This includes explicit or violent material, extremist ideologies, and other content that can negatively influence their beliefs, attitudes, and behaviors.

LOSING TRACK OF TIME AND ENGAGING IN DIGITAL ACTIVITIES FOR PROLONGED PERIODS:
(Ferrara et al, 2018)

ENGAGING IN UNSAFE AND ILLEGAL ACTIVITIES ONLINE: harassment, privacy violation, bullying, and exposure to inappropriate content (Andreassen et al, 2016) and (Ferrara et al, 2018)



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FINALLY:

Parents play a crucial role in safeguarding their children's well-being in the digital age. It is essential for them to actively monitor their children's screen time and promote healthy habits that encourage a balanced lifestyle. By doing so, parents can help their children avoid the negative psychological effects that come with excessive screen time.

According to recent research conducted by Cambridge University, excessive screen time has been linked to lower academic grades and developmental issues such as obesity, sleep disorders, and attention problems. This research emphasizes the importance of providing children with a balanced diet of interaction with the world, just like we wouldn't allow them to consume ice cream exclusively, no matter how healthy it may seem. Similar to the consequences of an unhealthy diet, a life consumed by digital media can be highly addictive and lacking in the necessary nourishment for proper development.

Like a nutritious diet, children require a balance between their engagement with the digital world and their involvement in physical realities. Encouraging activities such as physical exercise, social interaction, and creative play can help create this equilibrium. Parents should set reasonable limits on screen time and encourage their children to participate in a variety of activities that stimulate their minds and bodies. By providing this balance, parents can support their children's healthy development in the same way that good nutrition fosters their overall well-being.

In summary, parents need to be actively involved in monitoring their children's screen time and guiding them towards a balanced lifestyle. By promoting a healthy equilibrium between digital engagement and real-world interactions, parents can help their children avoid the detrimental psychological effects associated with excessive screen time. Just as a well-rounded diet contributes to physical health, a balanced digital lifestyle is equally essential for children's cognitive, emotional, and social development.

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To learn more and inquire about our training programs focused on maintaining a healthy digital balance, understanding children's digital rights, and promoting responsible social media use, please visit **www.ifdchild.org** or contact us via email at **info@ifdchild.org** Our team is prepared to support schools, universities, and communities in empowering children, adolescents, and parents in the digital age.